STATUS REPORT

Central African Republic: status report

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GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The country's GovTech and digital transformation strategy has still not been adopted: it remained planned or in draft (2025), alongside no whole-of-government approach to public sector digital transformation and no cross-government forum in which senior digital officials address strategy, data, technology and capacity. The ministry called in July 2018 for a firm to draft a national strategic plan, Centrafrique Digitale 2025, under the African Development Bank and European Union grant for the regional fibre backbone; its studies were presented to the ministries in Bangui in November 2021, and the Bank's completion report of April 2024 records all five of the plan's reports as produced and validated. No act adopting the plan had been published as at October 2026. A World Bank-financed call for a firm to draft a costed strategic roadmap for digitalising government closed on 3 January 2025. Digitalisation of public services and digital governance are an explicit strand of the Plan National de Développement 2024–2028, under which the government's e-government platforms are being built (February 2026). President Touadéra presents digital technology as an essential lever for boosting the national economy (May 2025).

Pieces of the apparatus exist without the whole. The Agence Centrafricaine de Développement du Digital was created by Loi 23.008 of 19 June 2023 with the mission of implementing the national strategy for the digital sector. The country has also established a dedicated data governance body as an autonomous institution and approved a data governance strategy, while having no open source software policy or action plan for the public sector and no national strategy on disruptive or innovative technologies (2025).

Identity is the one area worked through end to end. The government approved the final report of a strategic diagnostic of the digital-identity and civil-registration system at a workshop in Bangui on 17 April 2025, and a national civil-status policy has been validated for it to align to. The national digital identity system announced in late 2025 is not being deployed in any part, with assessments, procurement and an international tender all still ahead of it.

Delivery capacity is where the plans meet their limit: Effective Administration scored 25.7 out of 100 in 2023, 50th of 54 African countries, having gained 0.3 points across the decade to 2023 — effectively flat.

Legislation and regulation

The two newest additions to the Central African statute book arrive on the record as a lender's project results: the World Bank counts the enactment of two laws, on cybersecurity and on data protection, among the achievements of Component 2 of its Public Sector Digital Governance Project (May 2025). At appraisal three years earlier the same Bank had recorded a country with no comprehensive data protection body and neither cybersecurity nor cybercrime legislation (March 2022). What the data protection law does, and what has not followed it, is set out below.

Digital identity has no law of its own. Identity rests on identification laws dating from the 1960s, and the civil register itself sits under the Family Code of 1997. The country has no right-to-information law requiring government data and information to be published online, and no entity monitoring such a right (2025). The binding obligations the digital sector does carry tend to sit in telecoms law: registration of every SIM card against a valid identity document is mandatory under Article 61 of the 2018 Electronic Communications Law, an obligation that runs ahead of a card that residents of provincial towns have struggled to travel to Bangui to obtain (2023).

Enactment and effect are some distance apart. A universal service fund has existed in law since loi 18.002 of 2018 and a 2019 implementing decree, financed by a levy of 2% of operator revenue, and has never operated. The private printer of the national identity card charged above the tariff fixed in law for five years before an interministerial order of 26 June 2025 restored the statutory price, as the electoral roll was being finalised.

Data protection

The Central African Republic has had a data protection law since January 2024 and has no independent authority to enforce it. The independent supervisory authority the law provides for has not been established (2025), although the law gave the digital-economy ministry twelve months to set it up and hands its functions to the ministry until it exists; the position had not changed as at January 2026, with the law in place and the authority it provides for still unappointed.

The statute is a full one on its face. Law No. 24.001 of January 2024 sets out lawfulness, transparency, purpose-limitation and storage-limitation principles, classifies biometric and genetic data as sensitive, gives data subjects rights of access, rectification and erasure, requires a data protection officer, and provides for an independent supervisory authority. Its territorial scope extends to processing for security, defence and justice purposes, and it exempts purely personal use.

The exposure the law was written against has not moved much. At appraisal in March 2022 the World Bank recorded inadequate safeguards for both identification and civil registration data. The credentials themselves are produced under contract by a private company, the data protection law allows personal data to be transferred to states offering similar protection, and registration of every SIM card against an identity document is legally mandatory. Personal data is being collected under obligation, held by contractors, permitted to leave the country, and supervised by no independent authority.

Regional collaboration

The Central African Republic's newest state financial system is built to rules it does not set. JUMAC, the Treasury's cash-management application, is tied to the joint COBAC/CEMAC rules on claims and financial activity, and its architecture is regional rather than national: the Treasury has entered a strategic partnership with GIMAC, the CEMAC regional payments body, for infrastructure interoperable and compatible with the regional banking system.

That is the pattern rather than the exception. Instant payments reach the country through GIMACPAY, the CEMAC regional scheme operated by GIMAC and overseen by the regional central bank, not a national one; company records are searchable through the OHADA regional online commercial register; payment-services reporting is done regionally by BEAC; and holders of a biometric national identity card or CEMAC passport may travel visa-free within CEMAC under the 2019 Additional Act, given effect by a police circular in September 2024. In law the same holds: CEMAC instruments on electronic communications, payment systems and consumer protection apply alongside national law, and the 2024 data protection law itself sets conditions on transfers to CEMAC and ECCAS member states.

Physically the estate now touches its neighbours. The national optical backbone inaugurated in Bangui on 6 February 2023 runs the Bangui–Douala corridor and splits into spurs interconnecting with Cameroon and Congo, financed by the African Development Bank and the European Union, which places it within its Global Gateway strategy. It replaces an earlier attempt: the cross-border and transit component of the World Bank's Central African Backbone was cancelled, which the ITU attributes to reluctance to end the incumbent's monopoly on the international gateway. In May 2026 the government announced that it is pursuing a digital interconnection with South Sudan.

Standards

ARCEP acquired spectrum-monitoring and quality-of-service equipment in 2025 to police operator service quality, the state's most concrete recent purchase of an ability to check that a service meets the terms it is sold on. Government systems themselves are not built to a common published standard: there is no government interoperability framework, the systems in use run without a data quality framework, without any monitoring of uptime and without guidance for replacing legacy systems, and none of the financial management, treasury, customs, tax, human resources and payroll systems already deployed carries formal governance arrangements for compliance, security and audit trails (2025). Where a standard does bind, it is set regionally and not published for the public: the Treasury's cash-management application is built to CEMAC supervisory rules, and the scheme rules of the regional instant payment system are shared only with its members and participants.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Freedom of Association & Assembly scored 0.0 out of 100 in 2023 after a fall of 25.0 points, the country's largest single deterioration in the Ibrahim Index, while Civil Society Space fell 13.1 points to 35.5 and 36th of 54 African countries over the same decade. Speech pulls two ways: Media Freedom scored 61.9 and ranked 15th of 54 in 2023, up 6.7 points over the decade, while Freedom of Expression & Belief scored 15.4, ranked 52nd, and fell 7.5 points. Digital Freedom, at 65.4 and 20th of 54 in 2023, is simultaneously one of the country's ten best-scoring measures and one of its ten most deteriorated, down 14.7 points over 2014–2023.

There is no designed route into digital policymaking. The country has no national platform through which citizens or businesses can take part in policy decision-making, and no government platform for feedback, complaints or suggestions on service delivery, citizens and businesses are not involved in the design of any of the online government services the index assesses, and there is no right-to-information law to fall back on (2025). Nor is there much to debate from: the government publishes no progress, results or spending report for any of the digital domains assessed, and the GovTech institution's own annual report is internal and unpublished. Disclosure of Public Records rose 33.3 points over 2014–2023 to 33.3 out of 100, the country's second largest ten-year gain of any indicator, while Accessibility of Public Records fell to 5.0 and 51st of 54 — more is published, and less can be got hold of.

Participation therefore happens outside the machinery. The overcharging for identity cards was contested through the courts and on the street, by members of parliament and by a citizens' collective, and stakeholder research records a perception that the identity system is under foreign control, which the contracting of the card, escaping public-procurement scrutiny, does little to dispel. The direction of travel runs the other way: in June 2026 the media regulator framed AI-generated disinformation about the President and officials as cybercrime and proposed tighter identification of SIM-card holders as the remedy. In September 2026 a presidential decree created a communication-monitoring cell under the government spokesperson, one of its units dedicated to watching national and international media and social networks and countering rumours.

Finance

Financial sustainability

The Central African Republic's 2026 budget puts FCFA 2.5 billion of grant money into the public-sector digital governance project, up from FCFA 1 billion in 2025, in the year the World Bank grant behind it closes, on 31 December 2026.

The domestic-state share of the digital lines in the Central African Republic's budgets, at the appropriated stage, fell from 43.3% for 2025 to 39.9% for 2026, as grant-financed lines rose from about FCFA 4.5 billion to 6.0 billion while domestic lines rose from FCFA 3.4 billion to 4.0 billion.

Much of what the treasury carries is bills. The digital ministry's 2026 budget sets FCFA 1 billion to pay the invoices of the company V-care, a new FCFA 500 million for those of the company Mossi, FCFA 250 million for the administration's telephone arrears to SOCATEL and FCFA 118 million for six months of 2024 salary arrears at the digital development agency, against FCFA 500 million for the V-care invoices in 2025. No outturn against the digital appropriations had been published as at September 2026.

The one own-source mechanism in law has yet to collect. A universal service fund financed by a contribution of 2% of operators' previous-year revenue was created by the 2018 electronic communications law and a 2019 decree, and ARCEP listed completing its implementation among its 2026 priorities alongside a draft budget of FCFA 6.2 billion (April 2026), of which the state's transfer is FCFA 1.6 billion. Private money has entered on its own terms: the Central African firm EDEN TiiiT pre-financed the early phases of the planning ministry's Dûnîa platform (March 2026), with no repayment or licence terms published.

MoUs and other agreements

The largest figure in the Central African Republic's digital record commits nothing. Greenline Technologies announced in September 2025 that it had been awarded the privatisation of SOCATEL, the state telecom operator, under a memorandum signed in Casablanca foreseeing an initial US$150 million for a national digital hub, a Tier 3 data centre, expanded telecom infrastructure and cybersecurity frameworks. The privatisation entered an operational phase on 16 July 2026 with the underlying agreements still unfinalised, and nothing has been built.

The pattern repeats at every scale. Bangui signed a memorandum with the Emirati firm Transland on 30 July 2026 covering digital finance and land banking, presented as mobilising investment for structuring infrastructure projects while modernising land administration; no amount, disbursement schedule or governance arrangement was announced with it. It was signed by the minister coordinating the Cellule des grands travaux et des investissements stratégiques and extends the existing Bangui–Abu Dhabi cooperation track.

Two other sets of signatures sit on the record. The International Finance Corporation signed three collaboration agreements on digital financial services on 10 November 2025, one each with the Ministry of Finance, Orange Centrafrique and Ecobank Centrafrique, at a workshop it held in Bangui, and earlier the same year the government signed a memorandum with the Kigali-based AIAL Group for the construction of a data centre (January 2025).

None of these binds a party to spend. That distinction has bitten before: an earlier rescue of SOCATEL agreed in November 2020 needed an estimated €20 million to be raised before any work could begin.

New investments

The country's flagship digital operation closes at the end of 2026 with 54% of its funds disbursed and 78% of its activities complete on its strategic committee's count (August 2026), up from a third disbursed in April 2025. It is the World Bank's Public Sector Digital Governance Project, an IDA grant of SDR 25.1 million (US$35 million) closing on

31 December 2026, run by the Ministry of Finance and Budget and approved on 5 May 2022. Additional financing of SDR 4.8 million (US$6.4 million) was appraised in May 2025, adding a mining-governance component and taking the project to US$41.4 million.

Six digital-sector financing commitments touching the Central African Republic are on record, five of them specific to the country and one regional, spanning a window from 2017 to 2026.

Everything else is smaller and older. The African Development Bank is financing the country's share of the Central Africa Fibre-Optic Backbone with XDR 13,892,239, about US$19 million, for 1,050 km of cable on the interconnection roads with Cameroon and Congo over 2017 to 2024. France earmarked FCFA 3.28 billion of a €10 million budget-support convention to reforms at the finance ministry covering the Si_mba, SYDONIA World and e-TAX systems (November 2024). The UN Development Programme signed a financing agreement with the same ministry for the second phase of its public-administration digitalisation project in April 2024. The payment system Pata Polélé is financed by the European Union and delivered by Expertise France as one workstream of a four-year programme (April 2026), and the country was one of eight covered by an ITU ICT benchmarking project to 2023.

Donor money committed to the country's digital sector over 2017 to 2026 comes to roughly US$60 million. A further US$150 million announced in September 2025 is a private investment that has not been signed as financing.

The MDEPT data centre was not fully financed when the World Bank appraised it in March 2022, the appraisal document recording that the facility still required co-financing. And the government's strategic diagnostic of the identity system, financed under the same project, is also to serve as a tool for mobilising resources and coordinating partners.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The Central African Republic sits in the group of landlocked countries where the median data-only mobile broadband plan costs more than 20% of monthly income per head (2024), far above the UN Broadband Commission's 2% affordability target, and on the ITU's estimate about 13.8% of people used the internet in 2024; the regulator counted 1.56 million internet subscriptions at end-June 2026, a little over 23% of the population. The country ranks last of 54 African states on the 2024 Ibrahim Index's internet and computers measure, at 2.9 out of 100 in 2023.

It is landlocked, with no undersea cable landing of its own and most international bandwidth carried on costly satellite links. A national optical backbone, financed by the African Development Bank and the European Union, was inaugurated in Bangui on 6 February 2023, running the Bangui-Douala corridor down to Berbérati with spurs interconnecting Cameroon and Congo; the Bank's completion report of April 2024 records about 900 km of fibre laid. The cross-border transit component of the World Bank's Central African Backbone was cancelled instead, which the ITU attributes to reluctance to end SOCATEL's gateway monopoly; the state incumbent was still positioned mainly on fixed telephony in Bangui in 2021, and fixed broadband reaches under 0.1% of the population.

Orange won the first 4G licence in November 2024 and opened commercial service on 15 May 2025 in Bangui, Bouar, Berbérati and Bossangoa; Moov Africa renewed its mobile licence in January 2025 with 4G added to it, and Telecel obtained a 4G licence of its own in December 2025 and launched 4G+ service in Bangui in May 2026. ARCEP also granted the first passive-infrastructure licence in the country's history in July 2025, under which SOS Télécoms is to build pylons and technical sites and lease them to the operators.

Where the network does reach, it is fragile: Batangafo spent weeks without calls, internet or mobile money after the Orange network failed (July 2026).

Data Storage

A government data centre for the Central African Republic is still a project rather than a place, carried as one of six new centres a continental programme plans across the community, alongside five existing centres to be reinforced, at a stated total of US$9.00m and a quarter of the way through, four years after the World Bank's March 2022 appraisal recorded two of them under construction, one for public financial management and one at the ministry responsible for the digital economy. The ministry facility was designed as a national platform able to host systems and data from any public or private institution, specified to Tier II with a phase 2 extension to Tier III, and still required co-financing when it was appraised.

Four foreign-backed data centre projects for the country were announced in the twenty-one months to September 2026: a memorandum of understanding with AIAL Group in January 2025, a Tier 3 build written into the SOCATEL privatisation memorandum in September 2025, a Huawei proposal in May 2026, and a national data centre provided for in a memorandum with AMINI in September 2026. Each of them remains at memorandum or announcement stage, and an announcement is not a facility.

Fire damaged part of the national elections authority's data-processing centre in September 2026, weeks before residual elections due in October, and the government opened an investigation.

Nothing requires the data to sit in the country in the meantime. The data protection law allows personal data to be transferred to states offering similar protection; there is no shared government cloud platform available to government entities, no government policy on where government data may be hosted, and no monitoring or publication of cloud usage, security or savings (2025); and the country is served by cloud providers only remotely, from distant regions such as Johannesburg (2024), so what is hosted commercially is hosted a continent away.

Energy

Electricity reached 17.6% of the population in 2023 - 37.4% in urban areas against 2.3% in rural ones, among the lowest access rates in the world, and firms that do have a connection recorded about 28 power cuts in a typical month that year. Access to Energy scores 6.5 out of 100 in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, 51st of 54 African countries in 2023 and up 2.1 points across the decade.

That is the ceiling every digital ambition sits under. Inadequate electricity supply and a weak national backbone throttle the expansion of telecommunications networks, and the constraint is plainest at the mast: provincial relay sites run off-grid on generators and solar, are stripped by thieves and vandals, and wait on repair crews driving hundreds of kilometres from Bangui over degraded roads.

Generation is almost entirely water: renewable sources produced 96.5% of electricity in 2021, which measures near-total dependence on the Boali hydropower scheme and the newer Danzi solar plant rather than any decarbonisation achievement. What follows from that is a programme built partly off-grid: World Bank-financed solar mini-grids at Bambari and Berbérati, with five more mini-grids and off-grid solar solutions planned (2025).

The sector's most visible digital advance is on the billing side rather than the supply side, and the state utility gives the security and traceability of its receipts as its gain from it (August 2026).

Technical Capacity

The state builds and holds very little of what it runs. Pata Polélé, the government payment platform being rolled into ministries, was built with outside technical expertise working alongside the Office National de l'Informatique, the state IT body (April 2026), the country's identity credentials are produced under contract by a private company, and the World Bank's identification diagnostic left the government to seek donor funding to rebuild civil registration and identification (2017).

Nobody owns the problem at the centre: no ministry or department leads public sector digital transformation and no cross-government forum brings senior digital officials together over strategy, data, technology and capacity (2025), and government information systems run without a data quality framework, without any monitoring of their uptime and without guidance for replacing legacy systems. The flagship digital project shows the same thinness in its own execution, the World Bank recording planned procurement dates not respected, weak procurement documents and evaluation committees not convened on time (May 2025).

Cybersecurity

The law has arrived ahead of the institutions. A cybersecurity law and a data protection law have both been enacted, recorded as achievements of the World Bank's Public Sector Digital Governance Project (May 2025); when that project was appraised in March 2022 the country had no national cybersecurity strategy, no computer emergency response team and no security operations centre.

What the state operates is governed no more tightly than what it legislates: none of the government management systems in use - financial management, the treasury single account, customs, tax, human resources and payroll - has formal governance arrangements for compliance, security and audit trails (2025). International assessment puts the country in the weakest tier for national cybersecurity capacity in 2024, after a score of 3.6 on the 2018 index against 29.5 for Sub-Saharan Africa.

Two initiatives followed in 2026. After AI-generated deepfakes of President Touadéra and other officials circulated, the media regulator framed them as cybercrime and proposed tighter identification of SIM-card holders as the remedy (June 2026). A memorandum signed by the national internet and security unit with the data-infrastructure company AMINI, reported in September 2026, provides for a national computer emergency response team and a security operations centre; neither is recorded as built.

DPI

Data Exchange

Such exchange as happens between government systems in the Central African Republic happens inside the finance cluster: the only systems recorded as passing data to other parts of government are those for financial management, tax and customs (2025). Around them there is no layer at all. The country has no government interoperability framework (2025), and the government has no shared technical architecture or interoperability layer through which its parts can exchange data securely (March 2022). The systems that do run are operated without a data quality framework, without any monitoring of their uptime and without guidance for replacing legacy systems (2025).

The electoral database, with close to 2 million records updated every year, was the country's largest digital identity database (2017). An interoperable identification system is a goal of the diagnostic the government validated in April 2025 rather than a thing in service.

The joins that exist were made at the counter rather than between the machines. Business and tax registration are bundled at the Guichet Unique de Formalités des Entreprises, which issues the commercial register number and the taxpayer number in one registration (2022). Revenue collection went the other way, digitised on two separate tracks: an online tax declaration system built from the government's own resources, and a customs move from ASYCUDA to ASYCUDA World with European Union support (2022).

Digitalisation of public services is carried inside the National Development Plan 2024–2028 (February 2026).

Digital Identity and CRVS

The system meant to replace the Central African Republic's identity arrangements will not start being built before 2027: no part of the national digital identity system announced in November 2025 is being deployed, its implementation window runs from 2027 to 2032, and technical, environmental and social assessments, procurement and an international tender all remain ahead of it.

What exists meanwhile is a card, resting on identification laws dating from the 1960s; it carries the right to travel visa-free for up to ninety days across the six CEMAC states (2024). Most of the population holds no formal identification (2022). Refugees aged twelve and over are entitled instead to a refugee identity card under a 1968 decree (2024). The interior is reached by campaign rather than by permanent office: the contracted producer runs town-by-town missions capturing photograph, fingerprints and signature locally, with the cards printed in Bangui (October 2023), most recently to Birao (December 2025). The card's statutory price of 4,500 FCFA was restored by interministerial order on 26 June 2025, after five years in which the producer charged 6,000 to 6,750 FCFA against the tariff fixed in law.

Underneath the card, civil registration is paper. Births, marriages and deaths all fall within the legal scope of the register under the 1997 Family Code, but processing is manual (2017). An EU-funded project running since January 2021 is building a secure civil registration database in a pilot zone and has handed over its 100,000th birth certificate (2026). Civil registration is nonetheless the country's strongest public administration measure in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, at 50.0 out of 100, unmoved across the decade to 2023.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Telecel Centrafrique and the state utility ENERCA formally launched electricity-bill payment over Telecel Money at a signing in Bangui on 4 August 2026 — a service many subscribers were already using, so the ceremony consecrated it rather than started it, and whose gain for the utility is the security and traceability of its receipts (August 2026).

What it lands on is thin. About 13.7% of the population has access to a financial account (2022), and the cash-in and cash-out network runs at roughly 15 mobile money agents per 100,000 adults and is concentrated in Bangui (2023). Displaced people cannot open a bank or mobile money account without an identity card, passport or driving licence, and fewer than 5% of refugees hold a national identity card (2024).

Paying people has moved slowly and collecting from them faster. Patapaye, a pilot paying civil servants' salaries by mobile money through Ecobank and Orange Money, had signed up 2,500 of the 7,000 civil servants targeted, with about a fifth of users active, while salaries otherwise went out by bank transfer (2022); by May 2025 a World Bank project had put 1,702 civil servants posted outside Bangui without banking services onto mobile-money salary payment. In the other direction, Pata Polélé digitises the mini-recettes — the fees and duties levied across some twenty revenue-generating ministries — replacing cash and paper receipts with digital ones, with Justice, Finance and the Interior as pilot ministries and traffic fines among what it settles online (April 2026).

The rails beneath all of this are regional. The country is served by GIMACPAY, the CEMAC instant payment system launched in July 2020 (2023), whose scheme rules are not published (2023). The Treasury's modernisation around its own JUMAC application for the treasury single account was launched at the Agence comptable centrale du Trésor on 27 July 2026, integrated with the regional settlement platforms SYGMA and SYSTAC, with the stated object of closing the parallel accounts that hold state balances outside it.

Registries

The register the state has rebuilt nationwide is the electoral roll. Biometric voter registration ran with tablet-based kits in late 2024 ahead of the country's first local elections in about 36 years, the December 2024 drive deploying roughly 3,000 tablets and about 1,469 agents with UN Development Programme backing, in Bangui from 24 November to 7 December and nationwide to mid-December; where registrants had no documents, authorities were to rely on verbal testimony from traditional chiefs to establish who they were. The roll runs on a system supplied by the Dutch firm Genkey, in use since the 2020 general elections and revised in 2024, and the electoral database was already the country's largest digital identity database (2017).

Land is the opposite case. About 0.1% of the country's land is titled and registered, with the Conservation Foncière the sole body maintaining both the cadastre and land transactions and no separate digital cadastral system in existence (2021), and the title records it does hold are kept on paper, neither computerised nor scanned (2021).

Companies fare better. Central African entries in the OHADA regional commercial register can be searched online by name or RCCM number (2023), the register being regional infrastructure rather than a national system. Among surveyed firms, the share that were formally registered when they began operating has fallen sharply since 2011 (2023).

Two registers a modern administration would lean on are absent. There is no national social protection register: a unified social registry has been under development with donor support since 2018 and repeatedly delayed by limited technical capacity and institutional change, leaving programme-specific beneficiary registries to serve individual safety-net programmes (2025). And there is no digital address register or standardised addressing system, mail being routed by locality or district name.

Sectoral management information systems

The state runs a real back-office estate and audits none of it: not one of the government management systems in use — financial management, the treasury single account, customs, tax, human resources and payroll — has formal governance arrangements for compliance, security or audit trails (2025).

The systems themselves are substantial. The financial management information system is operational on off-the-shelf software, covering treasury and budget preparation and reaching both central and local government (2025); a customs system runs alongside it, with the customs and tax administrations merged (2025); a debt management system covers foreign and domestic debt (2025); and a payroll system is linked to the human resources system (2025), which is itself still being implemented and has no self-service portal for employees or managers (2025). That link produced the clearest result on record: a clean-up removed more than 2,000 ghost workers from the payroll (May 2025). What the centre cannot do is plan or measure: there is no public investment management system and so no project database (2025), the financial system captures neither spending against strategic goals nor non-financial performance indicators (2025), and the unified budget classification and chart of accounts covers central government only (2025).

In the line ministries the digital layer sits above the point of service rather than at it. DHIS2, the health information system, is run from central and subnational data offices and offers its users fewer functions than in Ethiopia, Tanzania or Uganda, every user interviewed saying it needs improvement (2024), and health data is still gathered on paper forms and registers, against poor internet connectivity and insecurity (2022). Education reports by text message: schools report in real time by SMS through EduTrac, in place since 2019, which stores the data on a web platform and supports the education management information system (2023), and police and gendarmerie units were supplied with office registers by the UN mission, 30 units in May 2018 (2018). The newest system is narrower still: the planning ministry launched an internal platform in February 2026 for its own budget, staff and project data, within one ministry rather than across government.

The first integrated criminal database was established on 9 October 2026, the UN mission financing the centre, equipment and servers and UNODC providing expertise, training and connectivity; extension to the judicial police and the regions is the stated next step. A second report records the centre's inauguration at the interior ministry.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

A single entry point to the state opened on 10 December 2025, when the Gouvernemental Centralisé portal launched, offering one route to administrative procedures, tracking of requests and complaints, and access to official documents. What can be transacted through it is narrow: health, education and tax services are announced as future modules rather than working ones (2025).

Tax is the exception that works. The tax administration launched e-Tax on 24 March 2025 with four modules, one of them registration for the unique identification number, and it is the only citizen- or business-facing government platform assessed as universally accessible across channels (2025), though online declaration was designed first for large taxpayers (2022). Beyond it there is no e-procurement portal and no procurement data published to the Open Contracting Data Standard (2025), no government job portal and no online portal for social insurance and pensions (2025), and no way to start a business online (2025).

Of the five citizen- or business-facing portals the 2025 index assesses — public service, tax, jobs, open data, and social insurance and pensions — only the tax portal exists, and the ten government systems the country does run are otherwise all back-office administration. Four separate government digital platforms were launched in the fourteen months to April 2026, each with a different owning institution and a different financier.

The country sits in the low group of the UN's E-Government Development Index for 2024, scoring below 0.25. The programme paying for much of the build is behind: the World Bank's public sector digital governance project had disbursed 54% of its funds with four months to run (August 2026), and the Bank records planned procurement dates not respected, weak procurement documents and evaluation committees not convened on time (May 2025). None of it is built with the people who use it: citizens and businesses are not involved in the design of any of the online services assessed, tax included (2025), and there is no platform through which they can take part in policy decisions, or give feedback and complain about service delivery (2025).

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The Bangui town hall signed a partnership convention with the Ivorian company BMI-WFS on 12 December 2025 to digitise the collection of the capital's municipal revenue, at a ceremony chaired by the minister for territorial administration. The town hall's own IT service had begun a census of city-centre traders in December 2020 to build a taxpayer database with an individual record for each.

Outside the capital the digital work that reaches the communes is civil registration, run from the centre. The civil-registry directorate reported in July 2026 a national civil-status register holding more than 225,000 birth records, registry centres rehabilitated with solar power and computer equipment, an integrated civil-registry software still in development and 77% of processing done by hand, and its agents were trained in Bangui on 16 and 17 July 2026 to scan civil-registry documents under a project financed by the European Union. No prefectural authority ran an administrative system of its own as at October 2026.

Rural digital data capture

Computers began reaching rural policing in the Central African Republic in 2025, when MINUSCA started fitting a small number of provincial police stations and gendarmerie brigades, Baoro and Kaga-Bandoro among them, with computers, printers and solar power so that investigation reports and procès-verbaux previously written by hand could be typed. Typing is as far as it reaches: the same mission supplied office registers to 30 police and gendarmerie units (2018), so what has changed outside the capital is how a document is produced, not the record it belongs to.

That shape repeats wherever the state meets people beyond Bangui. Health data is still gathered on paper forms and registers in the districts (2022), and the national health information system is run from central and subnational data offices (2024). Births and deaths are recorded by hand on non-standard paper forms, including at secondary registration centres in villages and at health facilities (2017). Schooling is the partial exception: rural primary schools keep registers and grade books on paper, but principals report enrolment and attendance to the education ministry by SMS into a central management information system, a channel opened in 2019 and still working in 2023.

Identity is the one thing captured digitally in the field, and it is captured by travelling. Because cards were long issued only in the capital, enrolment missions take the applicant's photograph, fingerprints and signature in the town itself and print the card back in Bangui (October 2023), and that remained how the interior was reached when a mission deployed to Birao, in the far north-eastern Vakaga prefecture (December 2025). Nothing captured this way stays local: the biometrics travel to Bangui, and so does everything else.

The infrastructure that would move any of it is thinner than the systems. The country's first free public Wi-Fi was installed at Bocaranga through Russian cooperation and inaugurated by President Touadéra in April 2026, one town and the first of its kind.

Technology

AI

The national internet and security unit signed a cooperation memorandum with AMINI, a data-infrastructure and artificial intelligence company, after President Touadéra received its founder on the margins of the UN General Assembly; the projects envisaged cover mining, agriculture, health, education, forests, climate and public administration (September 2026). No national strategy on the technology has been adopted. The digital-economy minister said in November 2024 that a national artificial intelligence strategy for 2024–2028 was being drafted, and no text of it had been published as at October 2026; there is no national strategy on disruptive or innovative technologies (2025), which is the heading an AI policy would sit under. In June 2026 the Haut Conseil de la Communication attacked AI-generated deepfakes of President Touadéra and other officials as cybercrime and put forward tighter identification of SIM-card holders as the remedy; it was a proposal, and nothing has been adopted since. The only rule on the books that reaches automated systems is the data protection law's extension to decisions taken by automated processing. No artificial intelligence or analytics capability was in operation in a government service as at October 2026.

ICT Industry

Nothing in the state's own machinery is set up to buy from a domestic technology sector: as at 2025 there was no policy to support GovTech startups or private investment in them, no government financing for innovation by startups or small firms, and no procurement rule giving their bids any preference. What commercial activity exists is the mobile market and its suppliers, and the structural change there has gone to a new layer rather than to new entrants — ARCEP signed a cahier des charges in July 2025 granting SOS Télécoms a licence to build and lease passive infrastructure, the first of its kind in the country, and the operators have been completing their 4G positions, Telecel launching 4G+ in Bangui in May 2026. Any firm working underneath that market does so through near-daily interruptions of grid power (2023).

Innovation ecosystem

The state runs no innovation function of its own: as at 2025 there was no public sector innovation strategy or programme, no government entity or innovation lab charged with it, and no collaboration with the private sector on it. What exists was built by donors — a digital training centre and start-up incubator opened at the University of Bangui in January 2024 with African Development Bank and European Union funding, part of a Bank programme that also committed a cybersecurity and e-certification platform and technical assistance to stand up a national digital development agency. The independent hub network is thin: AfriLabs' directory of African innovation hubs lists Centrafrique Tech as an active hub in the country (2024). Nor is there any outside measure of what any of it produces, the Central African Republic being absent from the 133 economies ranked in WIPO's Global Innovation Index 2024.

Capacity

Literacy

Enrolment is the Central African Republic's best-ranked education measure in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, scoring 41.3 out of 100 and placing 23rd of 54 African countries in 2023 after a rise of 8.1 points over the decade, while equality in education scored 17.6, ranked 52nd and fell 5.4 points. More children in school has not meant a better school system: education is one of the country's three worst-scoring sub-categories at 19.6 out of 100 and 52nd of 54 in 2023, up 0.9 points over the decade, with education quality at 0.0 and unchanged since 2014. Enrolment counts children arriving; the index holds no data for the country on whether they complete or on who teaches them.

Digital literacy has no public programme behind it, with no government digital skills programmes for citizens or for schools (2025). The enrolment figures themselves travel by text message: rural primary schools keep their registers on paper, and principals report enrolment and attendance to the Ministry of Education through EduTrac, an SMS channel still in use in 2023.

Training and skills

The government has no strategy or programme to build digital skills in the public sector (2025), and what training exists has been created and paid for from outside it. A digital training centre and start-up incubator funded by the African Development Bank and the European Union opened at the University of Bangui in January 2024, one component of a Bank programme that also covered a cybersecurity and e-certification platform and technical assistance to set up the country's digital development agency (2023). Civil servants have been trained under the World Bank's Public Sector Digital Governance Project, women a minority of them (May 2025), and a harmonisation and training workshop on the Pata Polélé payment system ran in Bangui in April 2026 for the ministries piloting it.

Formal qualifications run through the University of Bangui's Institut Supérieur de Technologie, which supplies most of the country's holders of a professional licence in computer engineering.

The government signed a five-year partnership with Russia on 9 October 2026, implemented through HSE University, for digital-governance training of public servants, joint research and expert seminars.

Research institutions

No Central African research institution was producing published work on the country's digital development as at August 2026. The teaching base exists: the University of Bangui's Institut superieur de technologie supplies most of the country's professional engineering graduates in civil, industrial, computing, mining and geological engineering, and runs a master's in engineering sciences.

Inclusion

Access to services

The Ibrahim Index measure of equal access to public services fell 18.7 points over 2014–2023 to 10.4 out of 100, 53rd of 54 African countries and one of its three sharpest declines on any measure (2023).

What a Central African meets at the counter is a document requirement, and the national identity card was held by fewer than a fifth of the population even before the 2013 crisis destroyed its central production site (2017). The 2024 biometric voter registration showed what that does to a service that must reach everybody: with registrants unable to produce documents, the authorities were to rely on the verbal testimony of traditional chiefs to establish who people were (October 2024).

The card is also a purchase, and its price is the longest-running access dispute in the country. The company issuing it charged above the legal tariff for five years, the pricing was contested in the administrative courts and on the street from 2020, and the government restored the legal tariff by interministerial order in June 2025, as the electoral roll was being finalised and with the card required in order to vote.

Others hold a different document altogether. Refugees aged twelve and over are entitled to a refugee identity card under a 1968 decree, yet a bank or mobile money account cannot be opened without an identity card, passport or driving licence, and fewer than 5% of refugees hold a national identity card (2024). For everyone else issuance travels rather than sits still, enrolment missions working town by town capturing photographs and fingerprints locally while the cards are printed in Bangui, as far out as Birao in December 2025. The government's own strategic diagnostic recommends more enrolment centres, decentralised processing of applications and a minimum service standard for issuance (April 2025).

Online, the gate narrows again. No citizen-facing government platform other than the tax portal offers universal or omnichannel accessibility, and information and communication largely remain inaccessible to people with disabilities, for want of sign-language interpreters and braille documents (2020).

Digital divides

Women's access to public services in the Central African Republic scores 0.0 out of 100 — the floor of the Ibrahim Index scale, last of 54 African countries, and 10.1 points below where it stood ten years earlier (2023). Equal socioeconomic opportunity sits barely above it at 4.5 out of 100, also last on the continent, after a fall of 15.6 points over the same decade. Both fell through the years in which mobile communications improved faster than almost any other measure the index tracks. Schooling splits the same way, enrolment among the country's stronger measures and equality in education among its weakest.

The lines that decide who ends up on the wrong side of this are cost, current and distance. A gigabyte of mobile data cost 19.4% of GNI per capita in 2020, and the country remained in ITU's group of landlocked states whose median data-only mobile plan costs more than 20% of monthly income per head, over ten times the international affordability target (2024). Electricity reaches a small minority of the population and is close to absent outside the towns (2023), fixed broadband barely exists, and the country has no undersea cable landing of its own, so for almost everyone connection means a mobile signal or nothing at all.

That signal is recent outside the capital, Orange having taken 4G to provincial towns only in May 2025, and where it fails there is nothing behind it: a network failure at Batangafo left the town without calls, internet or mobile money for weeks (July 2026). Coverage is in any case not use: the regulator counted 1.56 million internet subscriptions at end-June 2026, a little over 23% of the population, and a publisher's estimate put people using the internet at 12.0% at the end of 2025.

Data

National statistics

The statistics institute presented the third phase of data cleaning for the fourth general population and housing census on 6 August 2026, a step towards the definitive results of the country's first digital census, and its teams have been in the field since 20 July 2026 for a harmonised household living-conditions survey of about 7,000 households, collected entirely on tablets over six months.

In the ten years to 2023 the Central African Republic ran two health surveys, one household survey and one agricultural survey, and no labour force survey and no business survey at all. It has held a population census within the past twenty years, but no agricultural census and no economic or business census in that time (2023). The shape of its scores follows: data use, data services and data products all sit between 50 and 69 per cent on the World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators, data infrastructure between 20 and 49 per cent, and data sources — the pillar built from censuses and surveys — under 20 per cent (2023). The system is better at handling statistics than at generating them.

Capacity of the Statistical System scored 19.0 out of 100 in 2023, 53rd of 54 African countries, even after a ten-year gain of 12.3 points. The country is also hard for others to measure: the 2024 Ibrahim Index holds no data at all for the Central African Republic on 17 of its 96 indicators, 14 of them public-perception measures and the rest covering schooling and environmental enforcement.

What the state does collect routinely, it collects on paper. Civil registration offices record births, marriages and deaths by hand on non-standard paper forms (2017). Primary schools keep registers on paper and report enrolment to the education ministry over an SMS channel feeding a central system (2023). The latest national measure of birth registration completeness dates from 2010, before the 2013 crisis.

The strategic report on digital identity and civil registration validated in April 2025 recommends digitising the état civil, archiving records, mapping coverage and producing statistics systematically from registration.

Open data

Publication and access moved in opposite directions over the decade to 2023: Disclosure of Public Records rose 33.3 points, to 33.3 out of 100 and 27th of 54 African countries — the country's second largest ten-year gain on any indicator — while Accessibility of Public Records fell 4.5 points, to 5.0 and 51st. More is put out, and less of it can be had.

Across the 23 data categories Open Data Watch assessed in 2024, the average openness score is 5.2 out of 10, and ten of the 23 score 5 or below.

What is open is unevenly distributed. Government finance and pollution data are the most open official statistics, each at 7.5 out of 10, while balance-of-payments data scores 2.5 and food security data 3.5 (2024). There is no government-wide open data portal (2025); official statistics go out through the statistics institute's Open Data Platform portal, which in September 2026 it was preparing to migrate to version 2.0 under a national action plan, testing a local installation loaded with the national accounts. There is no e-procurement portal, with no procurement data published to the Open Contracting Data Standard (2025); with no public investment management system there is no project database to publish from either.

The government reports on its own digital programme to no one: it publishes no progress, results or spending report for any of the domains the GovTech index assesses — cloud, interoperability, data governance, data protection, digital transformation, digital skills, public sector innovation, startup support and online service delivery — and the GovTech institution's own annual report is internal and unpublished (2025). There is no legal lever against that either, because the country has no right-to-information law requiring government data to be made available to the public, and no entity monitoring such a right (2025).

Publication that does happen tends to be regional or documentary rather than national and machine-readable. The unified public-services portal carries ministries' official documents and regulatory texts (2025); companies are searchable by name or RCCM number through OHADA's regional commercial register (2023); payment-system reporting comes from the regional central bank, whose instant-payment scheme GIMACPAY shares its rules only with members and participants (2023). A public statistics portal is planned as part of a platform launched inside the economy and planning ministry in February 2026.

Use of satellite data

Earth observation had no established role in public administration in the Central African Republic, and no national space or geospatial data policy had been adopted, as at August 2026.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The American position in the Central African Republic's digital sector is a document rather than an operating asset. Greenline Technologies Inc., a US firm, was awarded the privatisation of the state telecommunications operator SOCATEL under a memorandum of understanding signed in Casablanca on 18 September 2025, which promises a Tier 3 data centre and a national connectivity network and was announced at US$150 million. The revival entered an operational phase on 16 July 2026 with the underlying agreements still unfinalised, so the firm's foothold is a claim on a company the state still owns.

China activities

The Chinese footprint is Huawei's, and it is an announcement rather than a facility. In May 2026 the government and a Huawei delegation discussed a programme to modernise the state administration's digital infrastructure that includes a Tier III national data centre, and the same partnership is to interconnect government ministries by microwave links and support a national data centre. What is at stake is the wiring of the ministries themselves, but no construction start, contract or completion date has been attested for any of it.

EU activities

The European footprint runs through the state's own administrative systems rather than alongside them, which makes it the deepest of any power's and the hardest to unwind. The tax administration launched its e-Tax platform on 24 March 2025, backed by the European Union under a 24-month service contract and covering electronic filing and payment (2025); the Pata Polélé payment digitalisation is financed by the European Union and delivered by Expertise France (April 2026); and France earmarked part of a €10 million budget-support convention to the finance ministry's reforms, covering the Si_mba, SYDONIA World and e-TAX systems (November 2024).

The same is true of the country's records of its own people. An EU-funded modernisation of the civil register, run by CIVIPOL since 2021, is building a secure digital civil registration database in a pilot zone, and the National Digital Identity System launched in November 2025 is co-financed by the African Development Bank and the European Union, which is to unify the civil registry and biometric databases under a single identification number.

On the network itself the position is longer-standing. The European Union places the national optical backbone within its Global Gateway strategy, and the African Development Bank's representative said it would end the country's "enclavement digital" by tying it to the submarine cables landing in its coastal neighbours (February 2023). The commercial layer above it is European too: Orange won the country's first 4G licence in November 2024. A digital training centre and start-up incubator funded by the African Development Bank and the European Union opened at the University of Bangui in January 2024.

Set against the announced but unsigned US pipeline, European money — France bilaterally, the European Union through its programmes and its co-financing — sits behind the World Bank and the African Development Bank among the financiers of the country's digital sector (August 2026).

Gulf/UAE activities

The Gulf footprint is a single memorandum signed on 30 July 2026. The Central African Republic signed a memorandum of understanding with the Emirati firm Transland on 30 July 2026 covering digital finance and land banking, presented as mobilising investment for structuring infrastructure projects while modernising land administration. It was signed for the government by Pascal Bida Koyagbele, the minister coordinating the Cellule des grands travaux et des investissements stratégiques, and extends the existing Bangui–Abu Dhabi cooperation track. No amount, disbursement schedule or governance arrangement was announced with the memorandum, so what the Emirati position holds in the country is a place at the table over the land register and the payment rails.

India activities

India held no position in the Central African Republic's digital sector, commercial or governmental, as at August 2026.

Digital sovereignty

The state's firmest recent act of control was over connectivity rather than data: in April 2026 the digital-economy ministry deactivated Starlink kits roaming in the country without homologation, citing national security and the traceability of users.

Over data the state has set no rule. There is no government policy on where government data may be hosted and no shared government cloud (2025), and the 2024 data protection law lets personal data go to states offering similar protection, with conditions on transfers within CEMAC and ECCAS. No instrument fixing where state data is held or under whose law it is processed was in force as at September 2026.

The core identity system is in private hands. The national identity card is produced by Al Madina, a company registered in Oman and run by a Lebanese businessman, whose selection led deputies to call the custody of citizens' data a matter of sovereignty (2020), under a contract that escaped public-procurement scrutiny (2023). The digital identity system announced in November 2025 is to put identity data under a new national identification office, with deployment from 2027. Where the national identity database is hosted, and under whose jurisdiction, had not been published as at September 2026.

The terms on which Huawei's programme for a Tier III national data centre and microwave links between ministries, the SOCATEL privatisation memorandum with Greenline Technologies, the AIAL Group data-centre memorandum and the memorandum signed with AMINI, whose stated aims include the state's technological sovereignty and the protection of its data govern data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026.

Regionally, a government data centre for the country is one of six new centres an ECCAS programme plans across the community.

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